UPSC CSE Mains 2027 · GS Paper II

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

World order · Major powers · Neighbourhood · Diaspora · Extended neighbourhood

Handwritten-style notes

Built from the Sarrthi IAS GS Mains Module (IR) handouts and class slides.
Bracket trees · diagrams · mnemonics · PYQ tags · current affairs
Right column and left binding margin are kept blank for your own use.

Personal study edition · for printing

INDEX

Part I · India and the World

0 Start here: how to use these notes 3
1 World order and India's foreign policy 5
2 Major powers and India 12
3 India's neighbourhood 18
4 Indian diaspora 24
5 Extended neighbourhood 29

START HERE: HOW TO USE THESE NOTES

✎ *Read once with a pen. Fill the right column with your class notes. Before a test, cover the recall drill at the end of each chapter.*

How IR is asked (PPT-1, slide 3): 4 questions, **50 marks every year.** Q9, Q10 = 10 marks / 150 words (~7 min). Q19, Q20 = 15 marks / 250 words (~11 min). Questions are **broad and statement-based**: test the claim, don't endorse it.

Box	Means
Pink	slide line / handout error
Yellow	trap or rule for the exam hall
Green	ready conclusion line
Blue dashed	definition
Navy	current affairs (verify dates)

APPROACHES SHEET (your teacher's): pick one for the BODY

No.	Approach	How to use	Best IR fit
1	**Stakeholder**	impact, limits, way forward	"to what extent", policy questions
2	**Supply chain**	process	corridors: Chabahar → INSTC
3	**GS Paper-wise**	PESTEL	"examine influence / relations"
4	**Level analysis**	personal → national → international	diaspora, soft power, global role
5	**Component**	parts the question names	"diplomatic, economic, strategic"
6	**SDGs**	"sustainable" word	climate, Africa, island states
7	**Syllabus**	broad question	groupings, effect of policies
8	**Demand / supply**	need vs offer	minerals, energy, labour
9	**P3I**	people, powers, processes, infra	connectivity, regional engagement
10	**Life cycle**	birth → growth → crisis → reset	Maldives, Bangladesh
11	**Temporal**	timeline	"evolution", "post-Cold War"
12	**SWOT**	S, W, O, T	"importance + challenges", "pros and cons"

Quick recall (teacher): Stakeholder → Supply Chain → GS Paper Wise → Level → Component → SDG → Syllabus → Demand/Supply → P3I → Life Cycle → Temporal → SWOT. **Every answer:** Intro (number / slide line / current hook) → Body (one approach) → Way forward → Conclusion (slide's closing phrase).

WHICH LECTURE FEEDS WHICH CHAPTER

Chapter	Class slides	Handout	Mains PYQs quoted
1 World order & foreign policy	PPT-1, PPT-2	Ch 1 pp. 1-21	2026 (4), 2025, 2020, 2019
2 Major powers	PPT-3, PPT-4 (Other Powers)	Ch 2 pp. 1-24	2017-2026 (10)
3 Neighbourhood	PPT-4 Neighbourhood	Ch 3 pp. 1-27	2024, 2022, 2015 (2)
4 Diaspora	PPT-6	merged pp. 72-77	2026, 2023, 2020, 2017
5 Extended neighbourhood	PPT-7.2, PPT-7	merged pp. 78-100	2024, 2021 (2), 2018 (2), 2016, 2015
6 International organisations	slides pending	merged pp. 101-143	to come

Sources: only your Sarrthi IAS handouts and class slides. The decks are typed (no handwriting), so "slide phrase" boxes quote the slides' own "core idea" and "conclusion" lines. Current-affairs boxes come from your July and August 2026 magazines (web items are marked). Mnemonics marked "own mnemonic" are not from class.

WORLD ORDER & INDIA'S FOREIGN POLICY

PYQ Mains 2026 (x4) · 2025 · 2020 · 2019

✎ *The world moved through six phases of power and rules. India's foreign policy answers each phase, but one thread never breaks: strategic autonomy.*

How IR is asked (slide 3): 4 questions, 50 marks every year: Q9 & Q10 (10m, 150w) + Q19 & Q20 (15m, 250w). Questions are **broader now**: a theme in a **wider context**; **statement-based questions must be tested, not endorsed** → write "agree in part, but...".

TEACHER'S ORDER OF STUDY (slide 5)

1 · World order (this chapter) → 2 · Major powers: US, China, Russia → 3 · Bilaterals inside the big picture → 4 · Place any theme in context

Basics

→ **IR** = how countries interact with each other and with IOs, companies, movements, people. Core question: **why do countries behave the way they do?**
→ **Foreign policy** = what a country wants abroad and how it gets it
→ **Geopolitics** = how geography, location, resources shape power
→ **Global order** = how power, rules and institutions are arranged

SIX PHASES OF THE GLOBAL ORDER

1 · till 1914	2 · 1919–45	3 · 1945–91	4 · 1991–2008	5 · 2008–19	6 · 2020–
Realism, BoP, empires	Liberal try fails	Cold War: 3 strands	Unipolar, globalisation	Crisis of liberalism	Fragmentation, churn

Handout alert: tables say Phase 5 = 2008–2019; slide headings say "post-2008 till 2020". **Rule:** Phase 6 starts 2020 (post-COVID). The world did not move in a straight line: every phase mixed power, cooperation and ideas.

PHASE 1 · REALISM (till WW I)

> *"A country that demands moral perfection in its foreign policy will achieve neither perfection nor security."* — **Kissinger**

Westphalia

→ **Thirty Years' War 1618–48**: religious + dynastic → shows danger of fragmented authority
→ **Peace of Westphalia 1648** → state sovereignty + non-interference; base of modern international law
→ France, Sweden grew stronger

Concept	Meaning
Sovereignty	supreme authority inside territory
Anarchy	NOT chaos: **no world government** above states
Security dilemma	A arms for defence → B feels threatened → both less secure
Balance of Power	stop any one power dominating

THE REALISM FLOW (slide 7)

Anarchy → Self-help → Mistrust → Security dilemma → Arms race → Balance of Power

Road to WW I

- → "Attack first" belief → ***Schlieffen Plan***
- → BoP could not prevent war; rival alliances
- → Trigger: ***Archduke Franz Ferdinand*** assassinated
- → Nehru: a "***nervous state of peace***" after the war

PHASE 2 · LIBERAL TRY, REALISM WINS (1919-45)

Wilson's 14 Points 1918 → League of Nations 1920 (collective security) → Great Depression 1929: protectionism, dictators → League fails: Manchuria 1931, Abyssinia 1935 → WW II → Hiroshima, Nagasaki 1945

Liberalism: war not inevitable; institutions, trade, democracy, law build cooperation ***without a world government***.

Collective security: all act against an aggressor; works ***only if major powers enforce it***. ***Deterrence*** = capability + credibility + communication; ***MAD***.

PHASE 3 · COLD WAR (1945-91): THREE STRANDS

Strand	Core idea	Examples
Liberalism	institutions → cooperation	UN 1945, IMF-WB, ***Marshall Plan*** (~$13 bn, also containment), NPT 1968 (→ SALT), Stockholm 1972, Schengen 1985; USSR: ***COMECON***
Realism	rivalry, arms race	***NATO 1949*** vs ***Warsaw Pact 1955***; Korea, Vietnam; ***Cuban Missile Crisis 1962***; Yom Kippur 1973 → ***bipolarity***
Idealism	peace, no blocs	***NAM, Belgrade 1961***; Nehru's ***strategic autonomy***

India exception: 1971 Indo-Soviet Treaty in the Bangladesh crisis; US sent ***USS Enterprise*** to the Bay of Bengal for Pakistan. Non-alignment ≠ no partners.

PHASE 4 · UNIPOLAR MOMENT (1991-2008)

Victory of liberalism

- → ***USSR falls 1991*** → US sole superpower; Poland, Baltics → NATO, EU; Yeltsin's privatisation
- → ***WTO 1995***; ***China joins WTO 2001***
- → US unilateralism: ***Afghanistan 2001, Iraq 2003*** → overreach
- → Shared issues: Kyoto 1997 (→ Paris 2015), 9/11 terror, cyber
- → Multipolarity seeds: China, India, Brazil, Russia → ***BRICS***

India's LPG 1991 (BoP crisis): GDP ***~$270 bn (1991) → ~$1.2 tn (2008)*** → ***economics enters foreign policy***. ***Unipolarity*** = one dominant power; ***hegemony*** = strong enough to write the rules.

PHASE 5 · CRISIS OF LIBERALISM (post-2008)

Trends

→ **GFC 2008** → faith in Western order falls
→ Shift to Indo-Pacific: **2010 China passes Japan**; Obama's **Pivot to Asia**; later Trump's **America First**
→ **BRICS NDB 2014**; G20 = crisis platform
→ **Brexit 2016** (~52% leave); Syrian refugees (Germany 1 mn+, Hungary resists)
→ Protectionism: **US-China trade war**

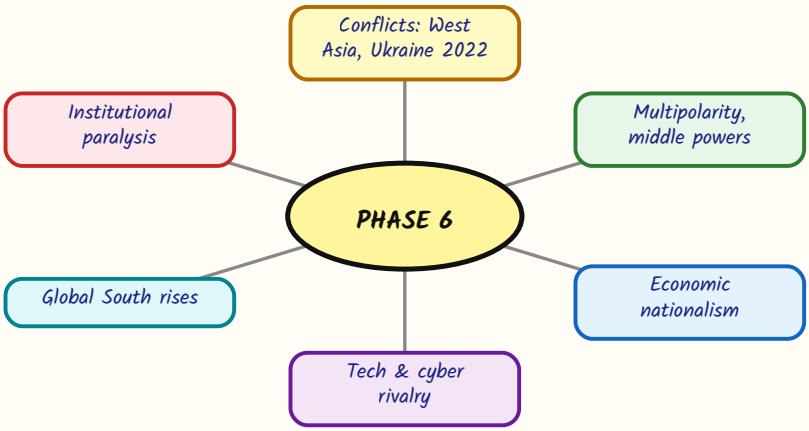
China's rise	Detail
Economic-strategic	**BRI 2013**; **Gwadar, Hambantota, CPEC** → less Malacca dependence
Military	**salami slicing**, grey-zone, **A2/AD**, South China Sea, Taiwan
Tech	**Made in China 2025** (2015); Huawei 5G
Institutional	BRICS, SCO, **AIIB**

US-CHINA RIVALRY SPREADS (slide 17)



Slide 17 "Overall": globalisation continued but became **more political, protectionist and security-driven**.

PHASE 6 · FRAGMENTATION (2020 onwards) PYQ 2025 · 2026



1 Conflicts

→ **Israel-Hamas 2023–**; **Feb 2026** US-Israeli strikes on Iran killed Khamenei → proxy to **direct state conflict**
→ **Russia-Ukraine 2022–**; Russia vetoed UNSC resolution

2 Power shifts

→ China: BRI + military; US: Quad + AUKUS
→ Middle powers: India, Brazil, Indonesia, Türkiye → **issue-based coalitions, competitive multilateralism**
→ India: multi-alignment, "**strategic patience and calibrated engagement**"

3 Econ nationalism

→ COVID → **deglobalisation**; **SCRI** (India-Japan-Australia); reshoring; **friend-shoring, de-risking**
→ US tariffs again (America First, 2025); **Graham Act 2026**: up to **100% tariffs** on buyers of Russian oil
→ China curbs **rare earths**; India: **Atmanirbhar Bharat**

Term	Meaning
Geoeconomics	trade, tariffs, sanctions, finance for strategic goals
Weaponised interdependence	use control of networks to pressure: **SWIFT** curbs on Russia, US **chip controls** on China
Transactional diplomacy	immediate bargains over shared values
Techno-nationalism	technology = national security

4-8

→ **Tech:** AI, chips, export controls; India: human-centric AI ("fortune in AI")

→ **Global South:** G20 Indonesia 2022, **India 2023**, Brazil 2024, S. Africa 2025; **AU in G20 (2023)**; G4, **Ezulwini Consensus**

→ **Populism:** America First, Brothers of Italy, National Rally, AfD

→ **Climate = threat multiplier**: Nepal glacier 2026, Cyclone Mocha 2023

→ **Paralysis:** UNSC veto; **WTO Appellate Body** no quorum → "selective multilateralism"

ESSENCE OF THE PHASE (slide 21) = your intro line



Area	US-led	China-backed
Development finance	IMF / WB	AIIB / NDB
Connectivity	PGII / IMEC	BRI / CPEC
Finance	Dollar, SWIFT	Yuan, alt payments
Tech	US AI, chips	Chinese 5G

Slide 23: China has **not replaced** the US-led order; minilaterals (Quad, SCO, I2U2, BRICS+) **supplement, not replace** institutions.

In the news · Aug 2026 CA US tariff on India: 25% reciprocal + 25% for Russian oil = **50%** (2025); Feb 2026 interim framework → **18%** vs ~3% historic average. A partner punished for an energy choice = **waning globalisation**.

In the news · Jul-Aug 2026 CA **Mecca Joint Defence Agreement** (Saudi-Türkiye-Pakistan): strategic hedging, but no command, no text, no common enemy = not an alliance. **UAE left OPEC** (May 2026). Five states leaving the **ICC**.

INDIA: GOALS & 10 DETERMINANTS

Three constant goals: **security, prosperity, an independent voice** (strategic autonomy). Policy shifts with global order, security, economic needs, ambitions.

Determinant	Aim	Example (slides 3-7)
1 Economy	markets, FDI, tech, energy, supply chains	China+1; Chabahar, INSTC, IMEC
2 Security	China, Pak borders; terror; maritime, cyber	LAC; oppose CPEC
3 Geography	Himalaya; Pak blocks land route; Indian Ocean	Malacca; Chabahar; A&N
4 Strategic autonomy	pragmatism, multi-alignment, no rigid alliance	Quad + Russia
5 Energy, minerals	diversify, no over-dependence	**Critical Mineral Mission 2025**

6 S&T	AI, chips, space, quantum, defence tech	India-US tech; India-France space
7 Values, history	anti-colonial, sovereign equality, reform	UNSC reform
8 Domestic, federal	states shape policy	TN: Lankan Tamils; WB: Teesta; NE
9 Diaspora PYQ 2026	asset + consular duty	Ganga 2022, Kaveri 2023, Sindhu 2025
10 Climate, new issues	climate finance, health, AI, oceans, space	**ISA, CDRI, Mission LiFE**

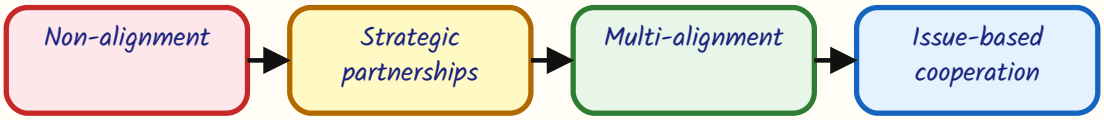
E S G S E S P D D C – "Every Smart Guy Sees Energy, Science, Politics, Domestic Diaspora Climate" – in the slide order. (own mnemonic)

In the news · Jul 2026 CA **PACTS** with Australia = India's 3rd tech-trust pact after **TRUST** (US) and **TSI** (UK). Hormuz disruption → LPG worries in India: determinant 5 live.

SIX PERIODS OF INDIA'S FOREIGN POLICY

Period	Approach	Markers
1947–62	Non-alignment, idealism	Panchsheel, NAM, "normative idealism"
1962–71	Security correction	1962, 1965 wars → defence; idealism stays, realism grows
1971–91	Strategic assertion	1971 Treaty, Bangladesh, **Pokhran-I 1974**
1991–98	Economic opening	LPG, **Look East**, **Gujral Doctrine** (trust + non-reciprocity + sovereignty)
1998–2014	Diversified partnerships	Pokhran-II 1998, **India–US nuclear deal**, G20, BRICS
2014–	Multi-alignment	Quad + BRICS + SCO; AIIB; Russian oil; **S-400** despite CAATSA; "bridge power"

CENTRAL THREAD: STRATEGIC AUTONOMY (slide 21)



Trap: Gujral Doctrine = **1991–98, neighbourhood**. Panchsheel, NAM = **1947–62**. Don't mix.

CONTINUITY, CHANGE, TRADE-OFFS PYQ 2019

Then	Now
Non-alignment	Multi-alignment
Distance from blocs	Engage many centres
Political autonomy	Econ + tech + security autonomy
Aid recipient	Development partner
Rule-taker	Rule-shaper

Handout line (p. 17): it is **not a shift from values to interests**. India keeps its values but now has more capability to protect interests.

Continuities: strategic autonomy, national interest, sovereignty (oppose CPEC via PoK), Global South, dialogue, Neighbourhood First.

5 trade-offs	Example
Autonomy vs deeper alignment	Quad + Russian oil
China: compete vs engage	LAC vs BRICS, SCO
Neighbour sensitivity vs security	Maldives, Nepal, Sri Lanka
Global South vs major powers	US, EU, Japan ties

Principles vs hard interest	Ukraine dialogue + Russian energy

7 challenges (constraints, not trade-offs)

→ Old institutions (UNSC, IMF, WB)
→ Domestic capability gaps
→ External shocks: COVID, Ukraine, Red Sea
→ South Asia least integrated
→ Tech dependence
→ Thin diplomatic cadre
→ Credibility: ambition vs delivery

In the news · Jul 2026 CA Multi-alignment in practice (July 2026): summits with ***Australia*** (inside AUKUS), ***Japan*** (sanctions Russia), ***Indonesia*** (ties with China, Russia) while India keeps Russia ties. "***Multi-alignment buys options; every partner has a reservation.***"

INSTRUMENTS: "THE INDIA WAY" (handout only)

Toolbox

→ ***Geoeconomics:*** energy diversification, China+1, critical minerals, Chabahar-INSTC-IMEC, ***DPI/UPI***, lines of credit
→ ***China:*** deterrence + de-risking + competition + selective engagement
→ ***Indian Ocean:*** net security provider, MDA, HADR; ***SAGAR → MAHASAGAR***
→ ***Minilaterals:*** Quad, I2U2, India-France-UAE, BRICS, SCO, G20, ISA/CDRI → ***supplement, not replace***
→ ***Soft power:*** yoga, Buddhism, diaspora, evacuations; works only with delivery

String of Pearls (China): Gwadar, Hambantota, Djibouti base

Diamond Necklace (India): Chabahar, Duqm, Sabang

Key words: ***Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam · Vishwabandhu · Voice of the Global South · reformed multilateralism · net security provider · first responder***

In the news · Jul-Aug 2026 CA UNSC campaign for **2028-29** under ***SHANTI***; India-hosted ***BRICS 2026*** (Guwahati Declaration). Use for "multilateralism" and the 2026 BRICS question.

PYQ ANSWER FRAMES

PYQ	Approach	Body
2025 sovereign nationalism after globalisation	Temporal	Phase 4 → 5 → 6; tariffs, friend-shoring, Brexit, populism
2026 Q10 BRICS as counterweight	Component	NDB, Global South voice, alt payments → limits (China, India differences)
2020 Quad: military → trade bloc?	Temporal	security origin → SCRI, tech, supply chains → verdict: both
2019 India lost leader-of-oppressed image?	Level analysis	NAM legacy → Global South 2023 (AU in G20) → "values + capability"

Recall drill: cover and answer

Westphalia gave which two principles?	Sovereignty, non-interference (1648)
Realism flow?	Anarchy → self-help → mistrust → dilemma → arms race → BoP
Three Cold War strands?	Liberalism, Realism, Idealism (NAM 1961)
China overtook Japan / BRI / NDB?	2010 / 2013 / 2014
Phase 6 essence?	Rivalry → realignment → fragmentation → multipolarity → paralysis
Weaponised interdependence example?	SWIFT curbs; chip controls
Ten determinants?	ESGSESPDDC
Six periods?	47–62, 62–71, 71–91, 91–98, 98–2014, 2014–
Gujral Doctrine?	Trust + non-reciprocity + sovereignty; 1991–98
String of Pearls vs Diamond Necklace?	Gwadar, Hambantota, Djibouti vs Chabahar, Duqm, Sabang

MAJOR POWERS & INDIA

PYQ Mains 2026 · 2024 · 2023 · 2021 · 2020 (x2) · 2019 (x2) · 2018 · 2017

✎ *The US, China and Russia shape the choices of every other country. India partners widely, aligns selectively and depends permanently on none.*

> *"International politics, like all politics, is a struggle for power."* — **Hans Morgenthau**

Major power = significant ***economic, technological, military capability*** + ***strategic intent to shape the order***; influences many regions and institutions through deterrence, agenda-setting, interdependence.

Response	Meaning
Balancing	oppose the dominant power
Bandwagoning	align with the stronger one: ***Belarus-Russia, Pakistan-China***
Strategic autonomy	decide alone (India)

Slide 2 core idea: "***Major powers shape the choices available to other countries.***"

Strategic entente = informal understanding to align or consult, ***not a formal alliance*** (e.g. Russia-China).

THREE POWERS: AMBITIONS & INSTRUMENTS

	USA	CHINA	RUSSIA
Goal	keep global leadership; burden-sharing by allies	"***Middle Kingdom***"; primacy via multipolarity	Eurasian influence; non-Western multipolar order
1	Regional balance: ***NATO, Quad, I2U2, AUKUS***; forward presence; 2026 NDS island chain ***Japan → Taiwan → Philippines → Borneo***	National rejuvenation: ***Made in China 2025***; AI, chips, EVs	Multipolarity: ***BRICS, SCO, EAEU***; ***BRICS Bridge*** (alt finance)
2	Tech-economic edge: tariffs, sanctions, export controls; ***CHIPS Act 2022***; ***Graham Act 2026*** (up to 100%); IPEF, friend-shoring	Regional reach: ***BRI, CPEC, Gwadar***; A2/AD; ***Two-Ocean strategy***; ***Djibouti***	Eurasia: ***CSTO***; nuclear doctrine; "nuclear power sustains influence beyond economic weight"
3	Finance & institutions: ***dollar***, UN, IMF, WB, G20	Tech leadership: "***New Three***" = EVs, Li-ion batteries, solar PV; ***rare-earth controls***	Energy leverage: oil to China, India; ***shadow tanker fleet*** beats G7 price cap
4	Western Hemisphere: renewed ***Monroe Doctrine***; Op Absolute Resolve (Venezuela)	Global governance: BRICS, SCO, AIIB; ***GDI, GSI, GCI***; ***Saudi-Iran deal 2023***	Connectivity: ***Northern Sea Route***; eastward pivot; Russia-N. Korea treaty

Slide 7: "US power is ***not only military***: also financial, institutional, technological." The US is turning ***interest-driven and transactional***.

Thin notes: AUKUS, Pax Silica, "Mythos 5", Op Absolute Resolve are only ***named*** in the handout. Don't invent details.

US-CHINA RIVALRY PYQ 2017 · 2024

Power Transition Theory: conflict likelier when a rising power nears the dominant one.
Thucydides Trap: the risk when a rising power threatens an established one.

Slide 13: "***Not a complete new Cold War***, because economic interdependence continues."
Slide 12: "***Technology has become a national-security issue.***"

7 dimensions

→ ***Military:*** SCS, W. Pacific; US allies Japan, S. Korea, Australia, Philippines
→ ***Taiwan:*** chips; US arms sales; China's ***Justice Mission 2025***
→ ***Tech:*** chip export controls; Sept 2026 Trump-Xi summit proposed AI dialogue
→ ***Supply chains:*** de-risking; China curbs ***gallium, germanium, rare earths***
→ ***Economic:*** ***Washington vs Beijing Consensus***; truce + tariff cuts on $30 bn each way
→ ***Institutions:*** US alliances vs BRI, AIIB, BRICS, SCO
→ ***Global:*** Global South matters more; ASEAN hedges

Impact on India	
Indo-Pacific	Chinese IOR presence → Quad, IORA matter
Border	LAC sharper; more partner cooperation
Supply chains	***China+1*** chance, but Chinese inputs a risk
Autonomy	multi-alignment needed
Governance	blocks UNSC/WTO reform; India as ***Global South bridge***

RUSSIA-WEST CONFRONTATION PYQ 2023

> *"The supreme art of war is to subdue the enemy without fighting." – **Sun Tzu***

Since Ukraine 2022

→ ***NATO grows:*** Finland 2023, Sweden 2024; ***Ankara Summit 2026: €70 bn*** for Ukraine
→ ***Sanctions:*** EU July 2026 package (energy, shadow fleet)
→ ***Energy:*** EU dependence on Russian gas ***45% (2021) → 12% (2025)***; Jan 2026 phase-out Regulation
→ ***Hybrid/cyber*** warfare
→ ***Russia-China "No Limits":*** trade ***~$228 bn (2025)***; shared interests, ***not an alliance***
→ ***Global South avoids choosing***

Impact on India	
Defence	spares, MRO risk → diversify, indigenise
Energy	Russian crude vital; Graham Act a challenge
Autonomy	balance Russia with US-EU ties
Connectivity	***INSTC*** hit; Central Asia, Iran routes
Triangle	Russia-China closeness shrinks India's Eurasian space

Slide 15: "***The world is not divided into two fixed blocs.***" Never accept "new Cold War" or "two blocs" without this qualifier.

INDIA'S APPROACH

JAISHANKAR, "THE INDIA WAY": the opening line for any bilateral answer

ENGAGE America → MANAGE China → CULTIVATE Europe → REASSURE Russia → BRING Japan into play → DRAW neighbours in

Handout core idea (p. 7): strategic autonomy under pressure: ***partnering widely, aligning selectively, depending permanently on none.*** US → tech, defence, Indo-Pacific · China → deterrence + engagement · Russia → defence, energy, Eurasia.

INDIA-CHINA PYQ 2026 BRI · 2017

Slide 17: *competition + interdependence + selective cooperation* = managed competition.

Phase	Keyword	Markers
1950–54	Postcolonial engagement	PRC recognised 1949; ties 1950; ***Panchsheel 1954***
1950s–62	Territorial rupture	Tibet; ***1962 war***; Aksai Chin lost
1976–88	Rapprochement	***Rajiv Gandhi visit 1988***
1993–2005	Border management	1993–96 pacts; ***SR mechanism 2003***; 2005 principles
2008–13	Economic engagement	trade up, imbalance wider
2017–20	Confrontation	***Doklam 2017***; ***Galwan 2020***
2020–24	Crisis management	Corps Commander, WMCC; ***Depsang-Demchok Oct 2024***
2025–26	Calibrated re-engagement	SR, WMCC, flights, visas

P-T-D-I-E-B-C-C — Postcolonial → Territorial → Diplomatic → Institutional → Economic → Border → Crisis → Calibrated. (own mnemonic, in order)

Convergence

- → BRICS, NDB, AIIB
- → Trade ***$151 bn (2025-26)***
- → WTO: public stockholding, SSM
- → Climate: ***CBDR-RC***
- → Multipolar order
- → Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, flights

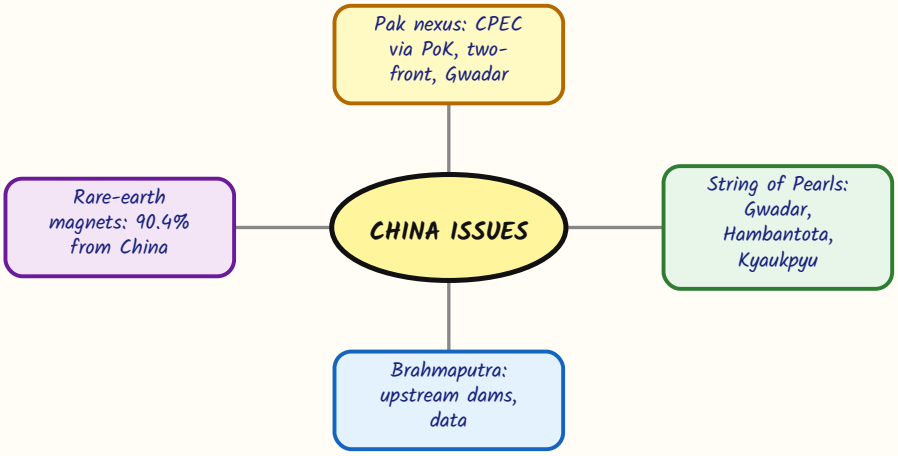
Divergence

- → Border: Doklam, Galwan; Arunachal names
- → BRI, CPEC, IOR presence
- → Global South rivalry: GDI, GSI
- → Deficit ***~$112.16 bn*** (FY26)
- → Rare earths, graphite, telecom
- → Brahmaputra upstream; Tibet (Dalai Lama succession, July 2025)

Sector	Length	Key points
Western (Ladakh)	***1,597 km***	Aksai Chin under China; Galwan 2020; Depsang-Demchok 2024
Middle (HP, Uttarakhand)	***545 km***	***least disputed***
Eastern (Sikkim, Arunachal)	***1,346 km***	***McMahon Line***; Doklam tri-junction

Total 3,488 km = 1,597 + 545 + 1,346; not fully demarcated. ***Trap:*** Doklam = 2017, EAST; Galwan = 2020, WEST.

FOUR CHINA ISSUE BOXES (slide 22)



Details

→ ***Pak nexus:*** China aided Pak ISR in the May conflict; Gwadar = "potential maritime dimension", ***not automatically a naval base***

→ ***Pearls → India:*** MDA, naval logistics, SAGAR/MAHASAGAR, Quad

→ ***River:*** independent monitoring; coordinate with ***Bangladesh***

→ ***Magnets:*** April 2025 China licenses ***7 heavy rare earths***; India imports ***all*** sintered NdFeB; demand ***8,220 t/yr by 2030*** → ***₹7,280-crore scheme, 6,000 t*** capacity

Close: the Three Mutuals = mutual respect + mutual sensitivity + mutual interests. Combine ***dialogue with deterrence, engagement with de-risking.***

In the news · Aug 2026 CA ***25th SR talks:*** 8-point consensus: 2 more military meeting points + 2 hotlines; Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation; Working Group on Border Management; more Kailash yatra batches. Modi-Xi met at the ***18th BRICS Summit***, New Delhi (12 Sep 2026, web).

INDIA-US: "PARTNERSHIP, NOT ALLIANCE" PYQ 2014 · 2020 · 2024

1947-60s	1962	1971	1998-2005	2005-08	2016-20	2021-	2025-26
caution; US-Pak	brief help	mistrust: tilt to Pak	Pokhran-II → Talbott talks	***nuclear deal***	LEMOA, COMCASA, BECA	Quad, iCET → TRUST	COMPACT, Mission 500, 10-yr defence

Convergence

→ Indo-Pacific: Quad, ***Malabar***

→ Defence: LEMOA 2016, BECA 2020; trade ~$25 bn (2023)

→ Tech: ***iCET → TRUST***, INDUS-X

→ Space: ***NISAR***; Artemis Accords 2023

→ Trade ~$149.4 bn (2025); ***Mission 500 by 2030***

→ Diaspora: 1.5% of US, $300 bn+ taxes, 82% STEM

Divergence

→ Russia: S-400, oil, ***CAATSA***

→ Tariffs: ***25% + 25% → 18%*** (2026 deal); GSP removed 2019

→ Digital: Special 301 list; data localisation

→ Pakistan: ***re-hyphenation***, mediation

→ H-1B: Indians 71% (FY24)

→ Climate: US left Paris (2026)

India SEEKS	India AVOIDS
defence interoperability	treaty alliance
technology access	technology dependence
joint exercises	automatic war commitments
maritime cooperation	foreign military bases

Quad, minilaterals	formal anti-China bloc
closer US defence ties	forced abandonment of Russia

Close (slide 29): from estrangement to strategic convergence; ***strategic pragmatism***: US capital, tech, innovation + autonomy.

In the news · Aug 2026 CA Trade ***US$239 bn (FY25)***, Indian surplus; US = 1st export market, 3rd investor. Frictions: 18% tariff vs 3% norm, SPS/MRL barriers. Fix: Bilateral Trade Agreement, Mission 500 roadmap, diversify.

INDIA-RUSSIA *PYQ 2020 defence deals*

1947	1960s	1971	1975	1988	2000	2010	2021
ties	MiG-21	Treaty	Aryabhata	Kudankulam	Strategic Partnership	Special & Privileged	first 2+2

Convergence

- → UNSC + NSG support; BRICS, SCO, RIC
- → ***Su-30MKI, T-90, S-400, AK-203***, Vikramaditya; MRO
- → Crude ***1.92 mn b/d, 36.5%*** (May 2026)
- → Trade ***$68.7 bn*** (FY25) → $100 bn by 2030
- → ***Kudankulam***; Rooppur (B'desh)
- → ***INSTC, Chennai-Vladivostok***; Gaganyaan

Divergence

- → Russia-China proximity
- → Quad seen with suspicion
- → S-400 delays, spares, payments
- → Trade gap: out $4.3 bn, in $61.4 bn (2023-24)
- → Russia-Pakistan engagement
- → weak in AI, chips, digital

Triangle: India needs Russia to keep ***enough strategic space in Eurasia, without expecting it to balance China***. Use Chabahar, INSTC, SCO.

Close (slide 36): from a ***defence-and-energy anchor*** to a diversified partnership (tech, minerals, Eurasian connectivity). Fix: ***India-EAEU FTA***, Make-in-India co-production, local-currency payments.

EUROPE: EU & FRANCE *PYQ 2023 NATO*

EU

- → ***Trade + Technology + Climate*** (slide 2)
- → 1994 pact; 2004 SP; FTA talks 2007, stall 2013; ***TTC 2022***
- → ***FTA concluded 2026*** ("Mother of All Deals"): ***99.5%*** of exports; dairy, cereals, poultry out
- → Goods $136.54 bn + services $83.10 bn (2024-25)
- → Friction: ***CBAM***, GDPR, AI Act, standards as NTBs, Ukraine

France

- → ***Strategic trust + autonomy + Indo-Pacific*** (slide 7)
- → ***Horizon 2047*** (2023); ***Special Global Strategic Partnership*** (Feb 2026)
- → ***36 Rafale + 26 Rafale-M*** (Apr 2025); 6 ***Scorpene/Kalvari*** (P-75)
- → Jaitapur 6 EPRs; ISA 2015; ***first EU country to take UPI***
- → Varuna, Garuda, Shakti; Tata-Airbus H125 line

France direction (slide 8): buyer-seller → ***co-production***; traditional → technology and innovation.

JAPAN & AUSTRALIA PYQ 2019 Japan

Japan

→ ***Strategic trust + economy + Indo-Pacific*** (slide 10)

→ ODA → private investment; ***JPY 10 tn*** target; FDI $40 bn+

→ Delhi Metro, DFC, ***bullet train***; Act East Forum

→ JIMEX, Dharma Guardian; ***ACSA***; SCRI; ***LUPEX***

→ Gap: trade $27.47 bn, ***CEPA underused***, slow projects, little tech transfer

Australia

→ "***Southern Indo-Pacific anchor***" (slide 13)

→ Trade ***A$50.2 bn***; ***ECTA → CECA***

→ ***Critical Minerals Corridor***; uranium under IAEA (2026)

→ ***PACTS*** (2026); Malabar, AUSINDEX, AUSTRAHIND

→ Gap: CECA farm issues; China refines minerals; diaspora strains

Closes: Japan → convert convergence into ***economic, industrial, technological*** cooperation. Australia → from convergence to an ***operational partnership***.

PYQ ANSWER FRAMES

PYQ	Approach	Body
2026 BRI made S. Asia a theatre	Level analysis	Neighbours (CPEC, Hambantota) → India security → regional influence → response
2024 West fosters India vs China	Stakeholder	US, EU, Japan, India gains → limits (autonomy)
2023 NATO expansion good for India?	SWOT	stronger West, tech vs Russia squeeze, energy → "agree in part"
2020 US vs Russia defence deals	Component	tech, interoperability vs legacy, spares → Indo-Pacific stability
2019 US can't place India	Temporal	1971 → 2008 → seeks/avoids table
2019 India-Japan	Component	strategic, economic, tech → gaps → convert

Recall drill: cover and answer

Bandwagoning examples?	Belarus-Russia, Pakistan-China
China's "New Three"?	EVs, Li-ion batteries, solar PV
Russia's alt finance idea?	BRICS Bridge
Two core ideas against "new Cold War"?	Interdependence continues; not two fixed blocs
EU gas from Russia 2021 → 2025?	45% → 12%
Border sectors?	1,597 / 545 / 1,346 = 3,488 km
Rare-earth magnet scheme?	₹7,280 crore, 6,000 t; China 90.4%
Three Mutuals?	Respect, sensitivity, interests
US tariff path?	25% + 25% = 50% → 18% (2026)
Russia crude share May 2026?	1.92 mn b/d, 36.5%
India-EU FTA coverage?	99.5% of exports; dairy out
Australia role?	Southern Indo-Pacific anchor; PACTS, CECA

INDIA'S NEIGHBOURHOOD

PYQ Mains 2024 Maldives · 2022 Sri Lanka · 2015 Mausam · 2015 India-Pak soft power

✎ *Geography ties India to its neighbours for ever. Politics and security decide whether that closeness brings cooperation or friction.*

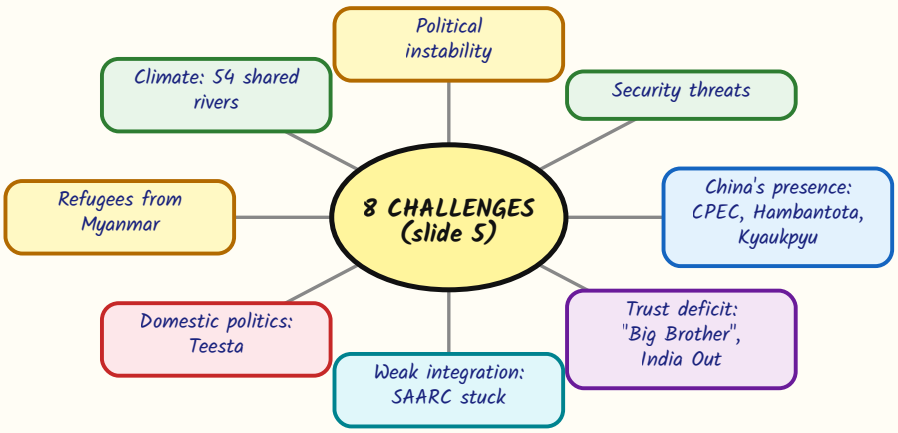


India and its neighbours (handout p. 1, slide 3)

India's interests (slide 4)

→ ***Security:*** terror (Pak), insurgency (Myanmar), Afghan instability
→ ***Trade, connectivity:*** B'desh → NE; Myanmar → SE Asia (Kaladan, Trilateral Highway)
→ ***Energy:*** Bhutan, Nepal hydropower
→ ***External influence:*** China
→ ***People:*** open border, Buddhism
→ ***Stability:*** disasters, sea lanes

Slide 4: "Neighbourhood First prioritises ***physical, digital and people-to-people connectivity, trade and commerce.***" ***Slide 5:*** "***Geography creates permanent interdependence, but politics and security determine whether it produces cooperation or friction.***"



Way forward (slide 6)

→ Respect sovereignty: ***equal partners***
→ Security cooperation; ***Vibrant Villages*** for border communities
→ ***Project delivery*** = credibility
→ Economic integration: border haats, Nepal-B'desh power via India; BBIN, BIMSTEC
→ Climate data-sharing; ***people-centric diplomacy*** that survives regime change

Closing line (slide 6): combine the ***Gujral Doctrine (1996)*** (non-reciprocity, non-interference, sovereignty, peaceful settlement) with Neighbourhood First → ***trust rather than dependence.***

Pre-1947	1947-49	1950s-60s	1962-65	1970s-80s	1991-96	1997-2013	2014-
imperial buffers	Partition	NAM, Panchsheel	security recalibration	1971, SAARC 1985, Cactus 1988	Look East, Gujral	BIMSTEC, IORA 1997	Neighbourhood First

PYQ Lab note: only 4 of 40 IR questions (2017-26) named a neighbour, each after a crisis next door. Prepare ***themes*** (crisis response, connectivity, water, China factor) with countries as examples.

PAKISTAN: "STRUCTURAL RIVALRY" PYQ 2015 soft power

Slide phrase: Credible deterrence + escalation control + limited functional engagement (slide 8).

1947–65	1971–84	1998–2007	2008–14	2014–19	2021	2025–26
Kashmir wars; IWT 1960; Tashkent	Shimla 1972; Meghdoot 1984	nukes; Lahore, Kargil, 2003 ceasefire	Mumbai	Uri → surgical strikes; Pulwama → Balakot	ceasefire renewed	Pahalgam, Op Sindoor, IWT abeyance

Still open

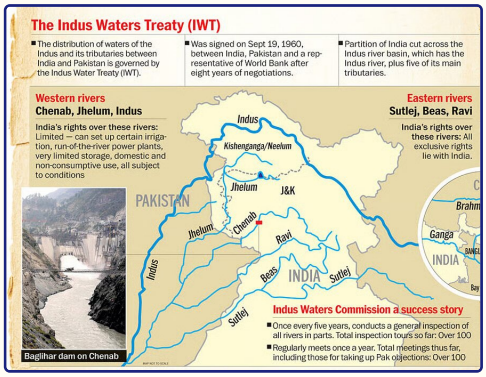
→ 2003 ceasefire, ***DGMO*** line; May 2025 stop-firing
→ ***1988 pact:*** nuclear-site lists every year
→ 2008 consular pact: prisoner lists twice a year
→ ***1974 Shrines Protocol***; ***Kartarpur 2019*** (suspended 2025)
→ SCO (Islamabad CHG 2024); SAARC stuck

Divergence

→ Terror: LeT, JeM; drones, cyber
→ J&K integral; ***no third-party mediation*** (Shimla)
→ Siachen: authenticate ***AGPL***; ***Sir Creek***
→ CPEC via PoK; two-front
→ IWT in abeyance (Apr 2025); Attari ICP closed
→ ***Stability–instability paradox***



Sir Creek (handout p. 5)



IWT 1960 graphic (handout p. 5)

IWT (19 Sep 1960, World Bank): Western = Indus, Jhelum, Chenab → Pakistan; India limited use (run-of-river). ***Eastern*** = Ravi, Beas, Sutlej → India. Commission meets once a year. Disputes: Kishanganga, Ratle.

Close: deterrence with escalation control now; humanitarian channels (fishermen, prisoners, pilgrims) insulated; ***durable peace needs a terror-free environment***.

AFGHANISTAN: "ENGAGEMENT WITHOUT ENDORSEMENT"

to 1950	1979–2001	2001–14	2015–16	2021	2022–25
Gandhara; 1950 Treaty	no Taliban recognition; Northern Alliance	development; 2011 SPA	Parliament, Salma Dam, Zaranj-Delaram	Op Devi Shakti	Technical Mission, Kabul

Convergence

→ High Impact Community Projects; people-centric not regime-centric

→ Trade ~$907.85 mn (FY26); ***Chabahar*** bypasses Pak; Shahid Beheshti 2024 deal

→ ***UNSC Res 2593***: Afghan soil not against others

→ Cricket, Kabuliwala, scholarships

Divergence

→ No recognition; women's rights; minorities

→ ISIL-K, Al-Qaeda, LeT/JeM; ***Death Crescent*** opiates

→ No land route; Iran sanctions hit Chabahar

→ China: ***Mes Aynak*** copper



Chabahar → Zaranj-Delaram → Ring Road (handout p. 8)

Close (slide 17): engagement without recognition, people-level goodwill, counter-terrorism and connectivity; small, locally maintainable projects.

BANGLADESH: "STRATEGIC RESET"

From "***Sonali Adhyay***" to reset. ***Longest land border 4,096 km***; link to the Northeast; Bay of Bengal security.

1971-72	1975-2008	2009-14	2014-15	2021-23	2024	2025-26
Liberation; Friendship Treaty	distrust; ***Ganga Treaty 1996***	Hasina: anti-insurgency	maritime award; ***LBA 2015***	Kushiyara; Akhaura-Agartala; pipeline	Hasina exits	reset

Convergence

→ Biggest S. Asian trade partner: ***$14.01 bn*** (FY24)

→ Chattogram, Mongla transit; ***40 MW Nepal power*** via India (Nov 2024); diesel pipeline 1 MMT/yr

→ Ganga 1996; ***Kushiyara 153 cusecs***; 54 rivers (JRC)

→ ***LBA: 111 + 51 enclaves***; SAMPRITI

Divergence

→ Hasina extradition request renewed (Aug 2026); minorities; Rohingya

→ ***Teesta*** unsettled (draft 2011); ***Ganga Treaty expires Dec 2026***

→ 864 km unfenced; border deaths

→ 2025 import, land-port curbs; trans-shipment withdrawn (Apr 2025)

→ China: submarine facility

Fix: time-bound Teesta talks ***with West Bengal***; post-2026 Ganga deal; CEPA; clear notice before trade curbs; BBIN energy. ***Geography, rivers, security stay permanent.***

NEPAL: "ROTI-BETI & OPEN BORDER"

Slide phrase: civilisational, people-centred; ***HIT formula*** = Highways, I-ways, Trans-ways. Closeness also breeds mistrust.

1816 / 1950	1989	1996	2015	2020	2024-25	2025-26
Sugauli; 1950 Treaty	trade-transit crisis	Mahakali	Op Maitri; Madhesi "blockade"	new map	10,000 MW pact	youth-led change

Convergence

→ Largest partner: **$9.39 bn**; 82%+ of Nepal's exports; UPI-NPI

→ Jaynagar-Bijalpura rail; ICPs; **Motihari-Amlekhgunj** pipeline

→ **10,000 MW** export deal; **Arun-III 900 MW**

→ Koshi 1954, Gandak 1959, Mahakali 1996

→ Surya Kiran; Gorkha regiments; GLOF relief 130 t+

Divergence

→ **Kalapani, Lipulekh, Limpiyadhura** (2020 map)

→ 1950 Treaty "unequal"; EPG 2018 report pending

→ **Agnipath** vs 1947 Tripartite pact

→ BRI framework (Dec 2024)

→ Pancheshwar DPR stuck

Fix: review 1950 Treaty; evidence-based boundary talks (B'desh LBA as model); **smart open border**; **Track-II**; respect Nepal's balancing.

BHUTAN: "BHARAT FOR BHUTAN, BHUTAN FOR BHARAT"

Story

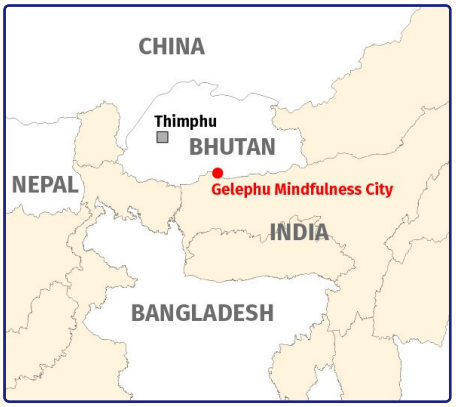
→ 1949 Treaty → **Op All Clear 2003** → **2007 Treaty** (more autonomy) → **Doklam 2017** (Siliguri) → diversification

→ Trade ₹12,669 cr (2024); 55%+ of FDI; 2016 trade-transit pact

→ **₹10,000 cr** for 13th Plan (2024-29)

→ 5 hydro projects **3,156 MW**; Punatsangchhu-II 1,020 MW (2025); ₹4,000-cr LoC (Jul 2026)

→ IMTRAT; RuPay, UPI QR; India-Bhutan satellite 2022; first **Vaccine Maitri** country



Gelephu Mindfulness City, near Assam

Issues

→ Bhutan-China talks near Doklam

→ BBIN MVA not ratified

→ Punatsangchhu-I delays; 60-70% loans

→ India ~80% of trade

→ 2013 LPG subsidy row

Close: move **beyond hydropower**; Kokrajhar-Gelephu & Banarhat-Samtse rail; sovereignty-first consultation on Doklam.

MYANMAR: "CALIBRATED ENGAGEMENT"

Slide phrase: Myanmar tests India's ability to **balance values, security and connectivity** (slide 33). Not whether to engage, but with whom.

Convergence

→ Trade ***$2.15 bn*** (2024-25); Rupee-Kyat (May 2024)

→ ***Kaladan***: Kolkata-Sittwe-Mizoram; Trilateral Highway; BIMSTEC, MGC

→ ***Op Brahma*** (Mar 2025 quake)

→ Ananda Temple, Bagan; 2 mn of Indian origin

Divergence

→ ***1,643 km*** border; Death Triangle; FMR curbs opposed in Mizoram, Naga areas

→ Post-2021 refugees; Rakhine, Rohingya

→ China: ***Kyaukphyu*** port

→ Sittwe got first cargo 2023, corridor unfinished

→ values vs national interest

SRI LANKA PYQ 2022

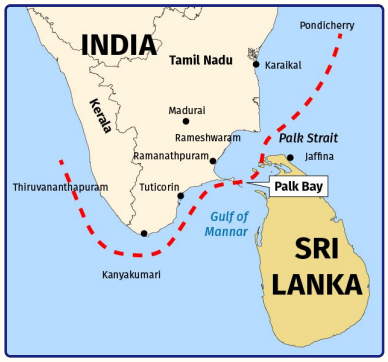
Story

→ Sirimavo-Shastri Pact → 1987 Accord, IPKF → post-2009 reconciliation

→ ***2022 crisis: ~US$4 bn***; co-chaired Official Creditor Committee

→ 2024-25: grid, LNG, UPI, ferries (Dissanayake)

→ Cyclone Ditwah → ***Op Sagar Bandhu*** (1,058 t+); $450 mn package



Palk Strait, Gulf of Mannar

Convergence

→ Trade ***$7.18 bn*** (FY26); ETCA talks

→ 60,000 houses; Kankesanthurai $65 mn; Nagapattinam ferry; UPI 2024

→ ***Sampur solar***; HVDC MoU; ***Trincomalee energy hub*** (with UAE)

→ Defence MoU 2025; Mitra Shakti, SLINEX; MRCC; CSC

Divergence

→ ***13th Amendment***; Provincial Council polls

→ ***Katchatheevu*** (1974, 1976); bottom trawling; Delft firing 2025

→ Adani left Mannar wind

→ ***Hambantota***

Handout alert: ISFTA dated 2000 (handout) vs 1998 (slide 35). Write "ISFTA" and check class notes.

MALDIVES: "LOCATION, NOT SIZE" PYQ 2024

1976	1988	2004-14	2016-23	2023	2024	2025-26
maritime boundary (slide: 1979)	Op Cactus	tsunami; Op Neer	India First	India Out	civilians; CEMSP	reset

Convergence

→ ***CEMSP*** Oct 2024; Ekuverin, Ekatha, Dosti; CSC

→ Trade $771.76 mn; FTA round 1 (Jul 2026)

→ Swap US$400 mn + ₹30 bn; RuPay; ***Favara-UPI***

→ ***GMCP US$500 mn***; Hanimaadhoo runway

→ 60,000 Indians; 1,000 civil servants trained

Divergence

→ "India Out" 2023-24; hydrographic pact not renewed

→ Chinese research vessel 2024; UTF Harbour suspicion

→ China-Maldives FTA (Jan 2025)

→ Lakshadweep row (Jan 2024): tourist boycott; 2 lakh+ tourists before

Close (slide 42): combine ***security cooperation with respect for sovereignty*** under MAHASAGAR; clear rules for Indian assets; Project Mausam.

In the news · Jul–Aug 2026 MAHASAGAR: India as "preferred security partner and first responder" (Aug CA). Favara–UPI corridor live (Jul CA). ₹4,000-cr LoC to Bhutan; Hasina extradition request renewed (handout, 2026).

EIGHT NEIGHBOURS IN ONE TABLE

Neighbour	Slide phrase	China footprint	One fix
Pakistan	Structural rivalry	CPEC, Gwadar	Deterrence + humanitarian channels
Afghanistan	Engagement without endorsement	Mes Aynak	Chabahar; small projects
Bangladesh	Strategic reset	Submarine facility	Teesta + Ganga 2026
Nepal	Roti-Beti, open border	BRI framework 2024	1950 Treaty review
Bhutan	B4B	Boundary talks	Beyond hydropower
Myanmar	Calibrated engagement	Kyaukphyu	Finish Kaladan
Sri Lanka	Crisis → connectivity	Hambantota	Fisheries framework
Maldives	Location, not size	FTA, research vessel	Sovereignty-sensitive rules

PYQ ANSWER FRAMES

PYQ	Approach	Body
2024 Maldives (15m)	Component + SWOT	Part 1 importance · Part 2 S/W/O/T
2022 Sri Lanka crisis (10m)	Temporal	old ties → 2022 $4 bn → connectivity → limits
2015 Project Mausam (12.5m)	Level analysis	cultural → bilateral → Indian Ocean strategy (thin notes)
2015 India-Pak soft power (12.5m)	Stakeholder	people, pilgrims · govts · army, terror → "goodwill follows peace"

Recall drill: cover and answer

Gujral Doctrine 4 parts?	Non-reciprocity, non-interference, sovereignty, peaceful settlement
Pakistan frame?	Deterrence + escalation control + limited engagement
IWT western rivers?	Indus, Jhelum, Chenab
Afghan phrase?	Engagement without endorsement/recognition
LBA 2015 enclaves?	111 Indian, 51 Bangladeshi
Ganga Treaty expires?	December 2026
Nepal disputed areas?	Kalapani, Lipulekh, Limpiyadhura
Bhutan core idea?	Bharat for Bhutan, Bhutan for Bharat
Myanmar border length / project?	1,643 km; Kaladan (Kolkata-Sittwe-Mizoram)
Sri Lanka 2022 aid?	~US$4 bn; creditor committee co-chair
Maldives partnership 2024?	CEMSP (October 2024)

INDIAN DIASPORA

PYQ Mains 2026 · 2023 · 2020 · 2017 (one every 3 years)

✎ *Indians living abroad are a "living bridge": they send money, ideas and goodwill home. But a bridge can also carry problems: visas, wars and racism become India's problems too.*

Indian diaspora = people whose origins trace to India, or Indian citizens settled abroad. India has the ***world's largest diaspora***: about 37 million (MEA, 2026).
Diaspora diplomacy = building ties with communities abroad and using their ***networks, knowledge and influence*** for national interest.

Who?

→ ***NRI*** → an ***Indian citizen*** living abroad
→ ***OCI*** → a ***foreign citizen*** of Indian origin; lifelong visa; can live, work, study in India (Jul 2026 CA)
→ ***PIO*** → Person of Indian Origin
→ Trap: citizenship decides. NRI = citizen, OCI = not.

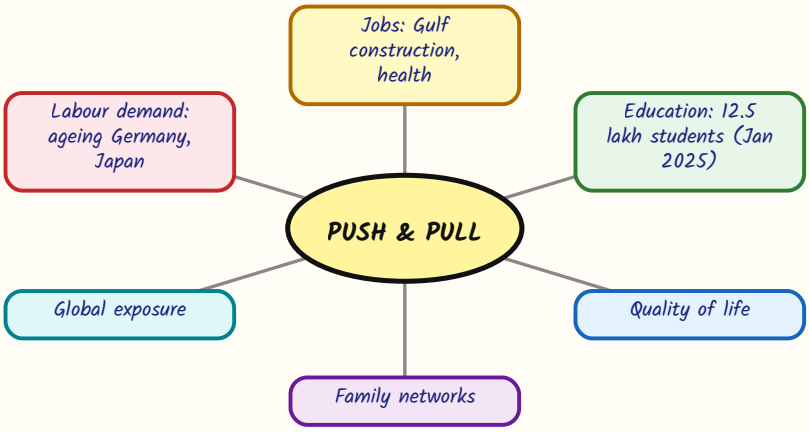
TOP 5 HOMES (Jan 2026)

Country	Indians
USA	**6.07 mn**
UAE	4.34 mn
Canada	3.24 mn
Saudi Arabia	2.75 mn
UK	1.28 mn

U-U-C-S-U – US, UAE, Canada, Saudi, UK: two "U"s first, a "U" last. (own mnemonic, kept in order)

Money vs headcount: the ***US*** sends the most remittances (27.7%); the ***UAE*** hosts the most workers (4.3 mn+).

WHY INDIANS MIGRATE



Students abroad (Jan 2025): about ***12.5 lakh*** → Canada ***4.27 lakh***, Australia ***1.96 lakh***; also US, UK.
UAE alone hosts over ***4.3 mn*** Indians.

ONE DIASPORA? NO, FOUR

Segment	Where	What they want
Migrant workers	UAE, Saudi, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman; SE Asia	Job security, fair wages, labour rights, safety
Professionals & entrepreneurs	US, UK, Europe, Canada, Australia	Careers, investment, tax, mobility
Students & researchers	US, UK, Canada, Australia, Europe	Quality education, scholarships, jobs
Historic (Girmitiya)	Mauritius, Fiji, Guyana, Suriname, S. Africa, Caribbean	Heritage, identity, culture

Slide 4 line to quote: "Different groups require different forms of engagement." A Gulf worker, a Silicon Valley founder and a 4th-generation PIO in Mauritius want different things.

WHY THE DIASPORA MATTERS PYQ 2023 · 2026

Money

→ **Remittances** US$135.4 bn (FY25) = **world's highest**, ≈ **3.8% of GDP**

→ Shares 2023-24: **US 27.7%**, UAE 19.2%, UK 10.8% → support Kerala, Punjab households

→ **Crisis finance:** Resurgent India Bonds **1998 → US$4.2 bn** (sanctions year); India Development Bonds; India Millennium Deposits

Business

→ Venture capital, mentors, market contacts

→ **Silicon Valley–India** network → SaaS, fintech, deep-tech

Politics

→ Explain India's concerns to host governments

→ Indian-American lobby backed the **2008 India–US Civil Nuclear Agreement**; **Howdy Modi**

→ Keeps India informed of global trends

Soft power

→ Diwali, Holi, yoga, cuisine, cinema, Ayurveda

→ **Girmitiya** links: Mauritius, Fiji, Guyana, Suriname, Trinidad & Tobago, S. Africa

Knowledge

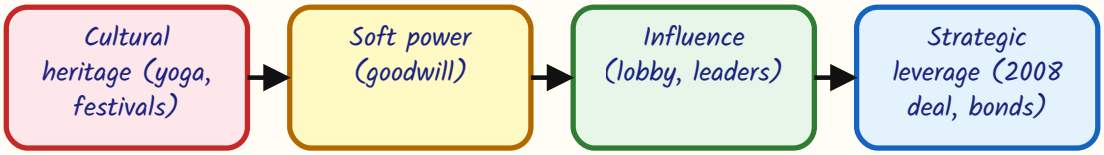
→ Tech, medicine, academia, research

→ Leaders: **Sunak** (UK PM 2022-24), **Harris** (US VP 2021-25), **Pichai**, **Nadella**, **Banga** (World Bank), **Sunita Williams**

Brain drain
skilled people leave → human capital lost at home

Brain circulation
they return with technology, capital, managerial skill → **the policy goal**

HOW HERITAGE BECOMES LEVERAGE (2026 PYQ chain)



In the news · Jan 2026 MEA on Pravasi Bharatiya Divas (9 Jan 2026): the diaspora is "**a living bridge** connecting India and the world". Seven months later Mains 2026 used the same words. **Lesson: UPSC borrows official phrases.** (web, verify dates)

WHERE IT STOPS HELPING — PYQ 2026 "critically"

7 limits (slide 8)

- → ***Remittances*** → mostly consumption, housing, health; not automatic investment
- → ***Trust*** → bonds and investment need trust in Indian institutions
- → ***Unequal access*** → networks informal; small firms can't use them
- → ***Political limits*** → Indian-origin legislators ***serve host-country voters***
- → ***Soft-power limits*** → culture ≠ diplomatic support
- → ***Welfare*** → visas, racism, wars become ***bilateral issues***
- → ***Security*** → small sections fund ***separatism***, attack missions

Write "can support", never "will support". Indian origin ≠ pro-India.

In the news · Aug 2026 CA "***Diaspora 2.0***": the Standing Committee (2022, as quoted) found missions lack a structured way to consult overseas Indians → move from ***ceremony to partnership*** on skills, investment and 2nd-generation culture.

PROBLEMS THE DIASPORA FACES

Challenges (slide 9)

- → ***Old law: Emigration Act 1983*** (recruiting agents, ***Protector General of Emigrants***) → outdated
- → ***Visas:*** H-1B and other curbs hit IT staff, students
- → ***Consular:*** delays, weak access in emergencies
- → ***Workers:*** poor pension, social security in some ***GCC*** states
- → ***Conflict:*** West Asia; evacuation needs host-country help
- → ***Racism:*** 400+ Indian student deaths, 2018–24
- → ***Identity:*** 2nd generation; loyalty pulls in a dispute

In the news · Jul 2026 CA Russian strike at ***Odesa*** killed 10 crew, ***4 Indian***. US replaced "Duration of Status" with a ***fixed stay*** for ***F, J, I*** visas. India fell to ***125th*** in the Global Passport Index. (verify dates)

EVACUATION DIPLOMACY (handout only)

Raahat 2015	Ganga 2022	Kaveri 2023	Ajay 2023	Sindhu 2025
Yemen	Ukraine	Sudan	Israel-Gaza	Iran
naval + air	via neighbours	navy, air, diplomacy	return flights	3,597 from Iran, 818 from Israel

R-G-K-A-S — "**R**eally **G**ood **K**ind **A**nd **S**wift" = Raahat, Ganga, Kaveri, Ajay, Sindhu, in date order. (own mnemonic) Don't mix with ***Devi Shakti*** (Afghanistan, Ch 3).

GAPS IN INDIA'S APPROACH

Gaps (slide 10 + handout)

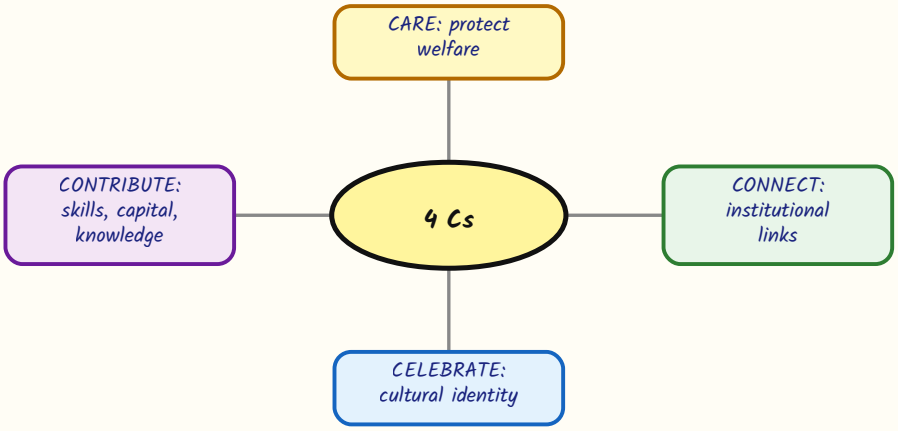
- → ***No single diaspora policy; no authentic data*** (Standing Committee 2025)
- → ***3,000+ unregistered agents*** (Oct 2024); weak penalties
- → Contracts hard to enforce abroad; low ***mission registration***
- → Thin consulates; weak MEA-state-recruiter coordination
- → Students pick unverified institutions
- → ***Overseas Mobility (Facilitation & Welfare) Bill 2024*** still pending

WAY FORWARD

Fix (slide 11)

→ ***Differentiated policy*** for workers, students, professionals, researchers
→ ***Real-time migration database*** (migrants + returnees)
→ ***Worker protection:*** labour pacts, agent registration with PGE, legal aid, pre-departure training
→ ***Consular + digital:*** liaison offices, one platform for MEA-states-employers
→ ***Talent: VAIBHAV, VAJRA, GIAN***; collaborate without permanent return
→ ***Capital:*** cheaper transfers, mutual funds, start-up links
→ ***Security:*** act on unlawful individuals, ***not the whole diaspora***

THE 4 Cs (slide 12)



*PM: the diaspora are "**Rashtradoot**", India's global brand ambassadors.*

Conclusion line (slide 12): India's diaspora policy should move ***from simple engagement to protection, partnership and productive global networks.***

PYQ ANSWER FRAMES

PYQ	Approach	Body in one line
2026 (15m) living bridge, critically	Level analysis	Household → national → bilateral → global; + and – at each
2023 (10m) benefits in the West	Component	Economic · political · one caveat
2020 (10m) "decisive" role?	Stakeholder	Host govts · voters · India → "important, not decisive"
2017 (15m) role in SE Asia	PESTEL	Economy · society · politics → limits (thin notes)

Handout error: it prints 2020 as 15 marks; the paper had it at ***10 marks, 150 words.***

Recall drill: cover and answer

NRI or OCI: who is an Indian citizen?	NRI
Size and top 3 homes?	≈37 mn; US 6.07, UAE 4.34, Canada 3.24 mn
Remittances FY25?	US$135.4 bn, world's highest, ≈3.8% of GDP
Resurgent India Bonds?	1998, US$4.2 bn, sanctions year
Four segments?	Workers, professionals, students, historic
Seven limits?	Consumption, trust, access, host loyalty, soft power, welfare, security
Five evacuations in order?	Raahat, Ganga, Kaveri, Ajay, Sindhu
Pending law?	Overseas Mobility Bill 2024 (replaces Emigration Act 1983)
4 Cs?	Care, Connect, Celebrate, Contribute
Closing line?	Engagement → protection, partnership, productive networks

EXTENDED NEIGHBOURHOOD

PYQ Mains 2024 · 2021 (x2) · 2018 (x2) · 2016 · 2015

✎ *Six regions beyond South Asia feed India's energy, trade, minerals and security. In every one, India's problem is less intent than delivery.*

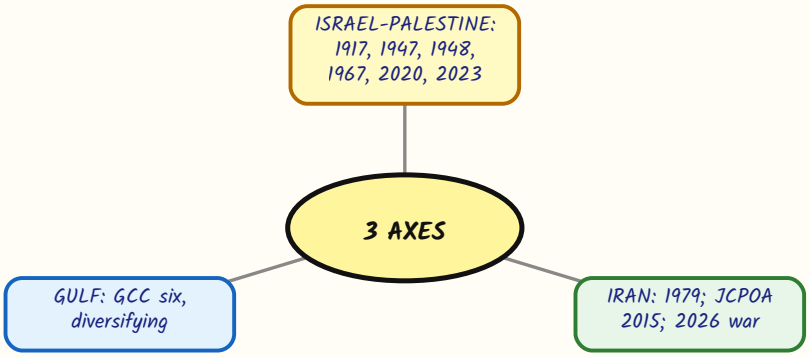
Direction	Region	Why it matters
West	West Asia, Gulf	energy, investment, diaspora
Northwest	Central Asia	connectivity, resources
W/SW	Africa	markets, minerals, Global South
East	ASEAN, East Asia	trade, tech, production networks
Maritime arc	Indo-Pacific	sea lanes, blue economy
Across the Atlantic	Latin America	energy, minerals, markets

W-C-A-A-I-L — "**W**e **C**an **A**lways **A**sk **I**ndia **L**ater" = West Asia, Central Asia, ASEAN, Africa, Indo-Pacific, Latin America. (own mnemonic)

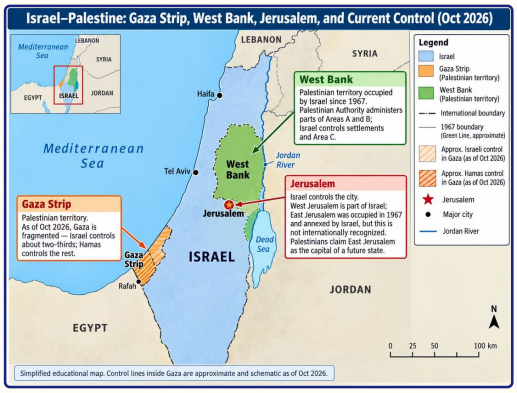
WEST ASIA: "STRATEGIC ENGAGEMENT WITH CAREFUL BALANCING"

> *"West Asia is part of our extended neighbourhood." — **Jaishankar**. India's **energy, diaspora, connectivity, maritime corridor**: Hormuz, Bab-el-Mandeb, Red Sea, Suez.*

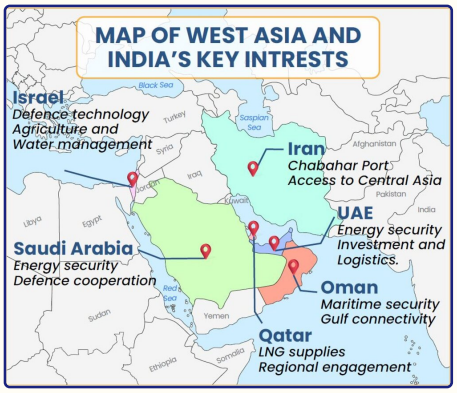
to 1947	1947–70s	1970s–91	1992–2004	2005–13	2014–19	2020–23	2023–26
trade, Sufism	Arab nationalism, Palestine	oil shocks, Gulf migration	***Israel ties 1992***	Look West	***de-hyphenation***	I2U2, IMEC, Abraham Accords	Gaza, Red Sea, Iran war



Israel-Palestine: Balfour 1917 → UN plan 1947 → Israel 1948 → 1967 occupation → Abraham Accords 2020 (UAE, Bahrain) → 7 Oct 2023 → ceasefire 2025. ***Iran:*** 1979 revolution; JCPOA 2015, US exit 2018; 2026 US-Israel-Iran war hits Hormuz. ***GCC:*** Saudi, UAE, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman, Bahrain; Saudi has not normalised with Israel.



Israel-Palestine (slide 6)



West Asia: India's interests (slide 9)

Major powers (slide 8): US = security actor, stop Iranian bomb · China = energy, BRI; brokered ***Saudi-Iran 2023*** · Russia = Iran ties, Syria 2015, OPEC+ · ***India seeks relations across competing camps.***

Israel PYQ 2018

→ Recognised ***1950***, full ties ***1992***
→ ***Barak, Phalcon, Heron***; water, agri, cyber
→ Trade $3.93 bn; FTA round 2 (Jul 2026)
→ ***Special Strategic Partnership*** (Feb 2026)

Palestine

→ ***De-hyphenated***
→ PM in ***Ramallah 2018*** (first)
→ ***Two-State solution***
→ Humanitarian aid continues

Slide phrase: "***Cooperation with Israel without abandoning support for Palestinian statehood***" (slide 11).

Iran

→ ***Chabahar***: bypass Pak; ***Shahid Beheshti 10-yr contract (May 2024)***
→ INSTC hub
→ Limits: sanctions, banking, war
→ ***Op Sindhu 2025***: 3,597 from Iran, 818 from Israel

Gulf

→ GCC trade ***$178.56 bn*** (FY25); ***~10 mn*** Indians
→ ***UAE***: CEPA 2022; $101.25 bn; target $200 bn by 2032; rupee-dirham; IMEC
→ ***Saudi***: SPC 2019; defence committee 2025
→ ***Qatar*** LNG · ***Oman*** Duqm; ***CEPA 1 Jun 2026*** · GCC FTA talks (Feb 2026)

Challenges (slide 17)

→ Balancing harder after 2026 US-Israel-Iran war
→ ***Hormuz, Red Sea*** → freight, insurance, inflation
→ IMEC slowed; Chabahar sanctioned → need ***multiple routes***
→ Workers: passport retention, recruitment abuse
→ ***OIC*** on J&K

Close (slide 18): simultaneous engagement with competing actors; strategic autonomy, diversified partners, secure energy and sea routes, citizen protection ***without rigid regional alignments***. Build ***both Chabahar and IMEC***; more SPR; Op Sankalp.

In the news · Jul-Aug 2026 CA Mecca Joint Defence Agreement (Saudi-Türkiye-Pak); India-Israel BIT in force (first OECD country on the 2015 model); Hormuz "reopen for 60 days", then new routes but no reopening (13 Sep 2026); Houthi blockade at Bab-el-Mandeb; UAE left OPEC (May 2026).

ASEAN: "CONVERGENCE, UNDER-REALISED ECONOMICS" PYQ 2016

> *"ASEAN centrality is at the heart of India's Act East Policy" – PM, Vientiane 2024.*
> *ASEAN = 11 members (Timor-Leste 2025).*



ASEAN (slide 20)

1991	1992 / 1995	2002 / 2010	2014	2019	2022	2025-26
Look East	Sectoral → Dialogue	Summit; AITIGA	Act East	IPOI	CSP	Prabowo; Indonesia visit

Convergence

- → Trade **$128.38 bn** (~10%); FDI $3.5 bn
- → Trilateral Highway, Kaladan
- → **UPI-PayNow** (19 banks); 5.9 mn travellers
- → ASEAN Power Grid; Indonesia nickel
- → **2026 Year of Maritime Cooperation**; AIME 2026

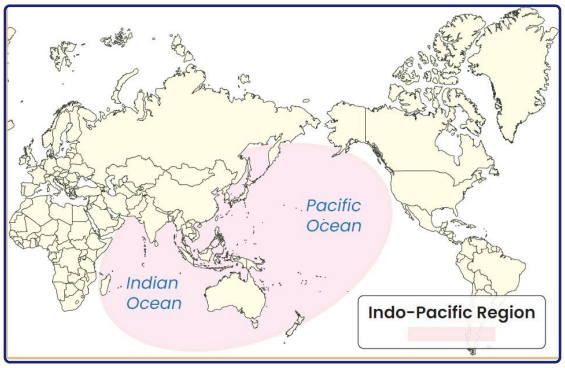
Challenges

- → Deficit **~$51.55 bn**
- → **RCEP exit**; rules of origin
- → China: **ASEAN-China FTA 3.0** (2025)
- → Kaladan, Myanmar delays
- → mineral processing concentrated

Close (slide 24): move from **strategic convergence to economic integration, connectivity, maritime cooperation**; "beyond ASEAN centrality as a slogan"; Viksit Bharat 2047 + ASEAN 2045.

In the news · Jul-Aug 2026 CA **BrahMos for Indonesia** (2nd SE Asian buyer); **Sabang** revived; Indonesian officer at IFC-IOR. China's rules for **Scarborough Shoal** (2016 award: a rock). 55%+ of India's trade crosses SCS + Malacca.

INDO-PACIFIC PYQ 2021 AUKUS



Indo-Pacific: E. Africa to the Americas (slide 25)

Why it matters

- → Chokepoints: **Malacca, Hormuz, Bab-el-Mandeb**
- → Supply chains; Northeast gateway
- → Minerals: Australia, Indonesia
- → **A&N** near Malacca; IFC-IOR, Op Sankalp

Who	Preferred order
India	free, open, inclusive, **multipolar**; ASEAN centrality; **no formal alliance**
US	alliances, forward presence, **deterrence of China**
China	against "containment" groupings
ASEAN	centrality, no blocs
Japan	**FOIP**
Australia	rules + deterrence

India's strategy (slide 29)

- → No **formal anti-China bloc**; China = dialogue + deterrence + de-risking
- → Link **IPOI** with ASEAN's **AOIP**
- → IFC-IOR, satellites; Quad, IORA, ADMM-Plus, EAS, MILAN
- → Minerals: access + processing + refining + recycling

Thin notes: AUKUS only named. Frame: AUKUS adds a military-tech layer; inclusive forums India prefers continue → "complement, not replacement". **Handout alert:** "Divzd cooperation…" line garbled.

In the news · Jul 2026 CA + web Mains 2026 asked if **IPMDA** bridges **SAGAR** and the Quad. Quad FMM, New Delhi (26 May 2026, web). New Zealand joined IPOI's maritime pillar; Japan aligned FOIP with MAHASAGAR.

CENTRAL ASIA: "A GEOGRAPHY GAP, NOT AN INTEREST GAP"

PYQ 2024 · 2018



Kazakh uranium · Uzbek minerals · Turkmen gas · Kyrgyz education · Tajik security (slide 32)

2012	2015	2017	2018	2019	2022	2026
Connect Central Asia	PM in all 5	SCO	Ashgabat	Dialogue	1st Summit	Uzbek CSP

Convergence

- → Uzbek trade $1.3 bn; Rare Earth Forum 2024; Uzbek MoU 2026
- → **Kazakh uranium**; TAPI (stalled)
- → INSTC cargo to Kazakhstan (Mar 2025)
- → DUSTLIK 2026; Afghanistan, terror, drugs
- → 16,000 students in Kyrgyzstan; all 5 back UNSC bid

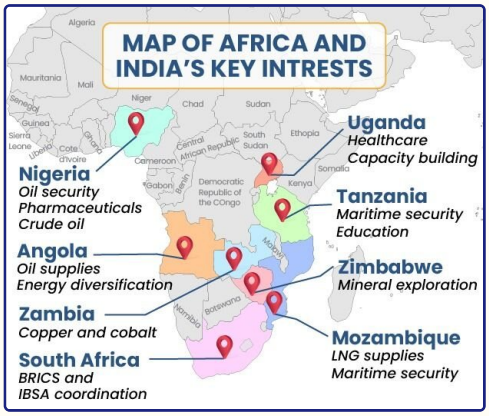
Challenges

- → No land route (Pak)
- → China trade **$106.3 bn**
- → **Chabahar waiver lapsed (Apr 2026)**
- → Afghan militancy; Bishkek 2024 violence

Close (slide 35): "**Connect Central Asia 2.0**": INSTC + Ashgabat + **EAEU FTA** (ToR Aug 2025) + SCO. Kazakhstan = largest uranium producer (Jul CA).

AFRICA: "FROM GOODWILL TO DELIVERY" PYQ 2021 · 2015

> *"Africa will be at the top of our priorities." — PM, Uganda 2018. Ansari: a "Two-Way street".*



Africa: India's interests (PPT-7 slide 5)

to 1990s	2004	2008	2018	2023	2026
anti-apartheid, NAM	Pan-African e-Network	IAFS-I	Kampala Principles	AU in G20	IAFS-IV postponed (Ebola)

Convergence

→ Trade **$93.69 bn** (slide); **AfCFTA** 1.3 bn people

→ Minerals: lithium, copper, rare earths

→ Energy: Nigeria, Angola, Mozambique; ISA

→ **e-VBAB**, ITEC, LoCs

→ AIKEYME 2025; IADD; UNSC reform

Gaps

→ Footprint far below **China**

→ Pharma quality; standards

→ Many rivals: US, EU, Russia, Türkiye, UAE

→ Sahel, Horn; **Op Kaveri 2023**

→ Delays; Red Sea; racial attacks in India; W. Africa neglected

Kampala Principles (2018), 10: Africa a priority · African priorities · open markets · **share DPI** · agriculture · climate · counter-terror + UN peacekeeping · open oceans · **no external rivalry** · fairer global order.

Close (slide 9): move **from goodwill to delivery**, aligned with **Agenda 2063**; regular IAFS; local processing; Africa Growth Fund.

In the news · Jul–Aug 2026 CA + web Mains 2025 asked on India–Africa **digital partnership**; NPCI–Bank of Namibia UPI licence (Jul 2025, web). India–SACU PTA terms signed; Chad leaving the ICC.

LATIN AMERICA & CARIBBEAN



LAC: India's interests (PPT-7 slide 13)

Story

→ Indentured diaspora: Guyana, T&T, Suriname

→ PTAs: **MERCOSUR, Chile (2006)**; CELAC

→ **KABIL lithium, Argentina**; 2nd CARICOM summit

→ 2025–26 visits: T&T, Argentina, Brazil

Convergence

→ Brazil trade $15.21 bn; Chile CEPA talks

→ India–Brazil minerals MoU 2026; ethanol, **Global Biofuels Alliance**

→ G4 (India–Brazil); IBSA, BRICS

→ 1,000 ITEC slots for CARICOM; Hurricane Melissa relief

Gaps

→ Mexico tariffs up to 50% (2026)

→ China–LAC **$549 bn**

→ Distance, Panama Canal

→ Argentina, Mexico in **Uniting for Consensus**

→ Language; Venezuela crisis

Close (slide 16): logistics, reliable projects, resilient chains can **turn distance into partnership**. "Commercially promising but strategically underdeveloped" (handout). Target $100 bn trade; Peru FTA, Chile CEPA.

SIX REGIONS IN ONE TABLE

Region	Phrase	India trade	China comparison
West Asia	careful balancing	GCC $178.56 bn	Gulf energy, BRI
ASEAN	under-realised economics	$128.38 bn	ASEAN-China FTA 3.0
Indo-Pacific	inclusive, no bloc	—	grey-zone, ports
Central Asia	geography gap	Uzbek $1.3 bn	$106.3 bn
Africa	goodwill → delivery	$93.69 bn	far ahead
Latin America	distance → partnership	Brazil $15.21 bn	$549 bn

PYQ ANSWER FRAMES

PYQ	Approach	Body
2024 Central Asia (10m)	Component	diplomatic · economic · strategic · significance · critically
2021 India in Africa (10m*)	PESTEL	AU in G20 · trade · ITEC · DPI · ISA → China gap
2021 AUKUS (15m)	Level analysis	bilateral → regional → global → verdict
2018 Israel "rolled back" (10m)	Temporal	1950 → 1992 → 2026 SSP → limits
2018 Ashgabat (10m)	Supply chain	port → INSTC → Central Asia, gains + risks
2016 Look East (12.5m)	Temporal	1991-2010 · 2014-19 · 2022-26 → verdict
2015 Africa pros, cons	SWOT	S · W · O · T → net positive if delivered

Handout errors: 2018 Israel question says "***rolled back***" (handout: "overlooked"); 2021 Africa = ***10 marks*** (handout: 15).

Recall drill: cover and answer

Six regions mnemonic?	WCAAIL
Three West Asia axes?	Israel-Palestine, Iran, Gulf
Israel ties: recognised / full?	1950 / 1992
Shahid Beheshti contract?	10 years, May 2024
India-Oman CEPA in force?	1 June 2026
ASEAN deficit?	~US$51.55 bn
India on China in Indo-Pacific?	Dialogue + deterrence + de-risking
Central Asia phrase?	Geography gap, not interest gap
Kampala Principles year?	2018 (10 principles)
Africa close?	Goodwill → delivery, Agenda 2063
China-LAC trade?	~US$549 bn (2025)

CURRENT AFFAIRS

International Relations · September 2026

11 items

Built only from the Sarrthi IAS monthly current-affairs magazine.
Red tag = Prelims + Mains, blue = Mains, green = Prelims.
Right-hand column is blank for your own notes.

Index

September 2026

3.1 US-China relations: the Washington summit 4
3.2 18th BRICS Summit: New Delhi Declaration 4
3.3 26th SCO Summit: Bishkek Declaration 5
3.4 India and Central Asia 6
3.5 India-Mercosur: expanding the PTA 7
3.6.1 UNGA "Correct the Map" resolution 8
3.6.2 US-Denmark-Greenland defence agreement 8
3.6.3 Indus Waters Treaty: Court of Arbitration ruling 8
3.7 IR quick updates 9
3.8 High-level visits: Belgium and Luxembourg 9
3.9 Conflict areas in news 10

September 2026

International Relations

3.1 US-China relations: the Washington summit

PRELIMS + MAINS

What: The Chinese president made a state visit to Washington; both sides agreed to build a "constructive relationship of strategic stability" based on respect, fairness and reciprocity.

Timeline

→ early 2025 tariffs raised sharply; 2025 Geneva talks cut tariffs for a trial period and China showed leverage with rare-earth export controls; Busan meeting suspended the controls and cut US tariffs; May 2026 Beijing set up Boards of Trade and Investment and the "strategic stability" formula.

Outcomes

→ 30-for-30 (favourable tariff treatment for $30 billion of non-sensitive goods each way); Busan truce extended to January 2027; Boards of Trade and Investment operational; working group on farm market access; dialogue on AI risks and an AI-incident channel; China export controls on two fentanyl precursors; militaries to conclude a crisis-communication memorandum (not yet signed); support for each other's G20 and APEC hosting; Iran must never have a nuclear weapon; opposed tolls on international waterways.

Unresolved

→ Taiwan (China asks the US to "oppose" independence, the US "does not support" it; about $14 billion arms package on hold); short truce; chip export controls; trade imbalances and overcapacity; rare-earth supply with no agreed figures.

Why rivalry persists

→ power and order, Taiwan and South China Sea, subsidies and trade, AI and chips, critical minerals (China refines about 91% of magnet rare earths, IEA), BRI vs AIIB-type institutions. Why they cooperate: interdependence, escalation risk, costs of tariffs, selective easing (January 2026 licences for some AI chips), mutual leverage ("mutually assured disruption").

India

→ rivalry raises India's value as a partner and China+1 destination; a US-China bargain could lower it and cheaper Chinese goods may hit Indian exporters; critical-mineral exposure; pressure on strategic autonomy.

Way forward

→ raise own value; convert China+1 into investment (logistics, value addition, electronics, semiconductors); diversify trade and inputs (National Critical Mineral Mission); build technology capacity (India Semiconductor Mission); strengthen maritime partnerships (Quad, ASEAN).

PRELIMS FODDER

- APEC: established 1989, 21 member economies, Secretariat in Singapore; India is not a member.
- Three Joint Communiques: 1972 (Shanghai), 1979 (diplomatic relations), 1982 (arms sales to Taiwan). Taiwan Relations Act (1979).
- Four parts of strategic stability (Wang Yi): positive, healthy, constant, lasting.
- De-risking vs decoupling. Weaponised interdependence (Farrell and Newman, 2019). Thucydides Trap (Graham Allison). G2.

MAINS FODDER

- Conclusion: Washington marks stabilisation, not settlement; India must stay valuable either way through resilience, capability and strategic autonomy.
- Keywords: Strategic stability; Managed rivalry; China+1; Critical minerals; Strategic autonomy

PYQ: 2021, 2024 and 2025 Mains questions on US-China rivalry, West fostering India against China, and sovereign nationalism after globalisation.

3.2 18th BRICS Summit: New Delhi Declaration

PRELIMS + MAINS

What: India hosted the 18th BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, in September 2026; the New Delhi Declaration was adopted by consensus. 20 years of BRICS; India's fourth chairship (2012, 2016, 2021, 2026). Theme: Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability.

Political	→ bigger role for developing countries in the UNSC (China and Russia restated support for India's and Brazil's aspirations; Africa's position under the Ezulwini Consensus); condemned the April 2025 Pahalgam attack, zero tolerance, early adoption of CCIT; West Asia "deep concern", maximum restraint, two-state solution on 1967 borders and full UN membership for Palestine.
Economic	→ opposed unilateral tariffs and non-tariff barriers including CBAM; restore WTO dispute settlement; IMF quota reform under the Diriyah Guiding Principles; BRICS Payment Task Force on interoperability and local-currency settlement (no common currency); India-led BRICS Risk Lab at GIFT City; Jaipur Consensus on invoice discounting for MSMEs; BRICS Grain Exchange discussions; BRICS AGRIN set up.
Technology and health	→ BRICS Digital Public Infrastructure Repository (India's proposal); Leaders' Statement on Global Governance of AI; BRICS Mission for Healthy Lifestyle (2026-29) with NIMHANS Bengaluru as Centre of Excellence; early warning sub-working group for infectious diseases. China hosts the 19th summit in 2027.
Limits	→ the declaration does not name the US on tariffs, does not name countries in the West Asia conflict, and omits Ukraine.
India's gains	→ multi-alignment and strategic autonomy; bridging role (foreign ministers had failed to agree in May but leaders reached consensus though Iran and UAE are on opposite sides); China's president in India for the first time since 2019; PM's 3R agenda (Representation, Responsiveness, Rule-making) and "pyramid of privilege to platform of partnership".
Sidelines	→ India-China talked of a "fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable" boundary resolution and India raised the trade deficit (about USD 112 billion in FY26; trade about USD 151 billion); India-Russia reaffirmed USD 100 billion trade by 2030; Iran-UAE held their highest-level meeting since the 2026 war began.
Limits of BRICS	→ Iran-UAE and Egypt-Ethiopia (GERD) divisions; vague consensus language (Rio 2025 condemned strikes on Iran, New Delhi 2026 only "deep concern"); China's outsized weight; payment linkage needs compatible systems; no permanent secretariat so implementation gap.
Way forward	→ consolidate before expanding; Troika-based continuity and a digital decision tracker; payment interoperability over a common currency; insulate food, health, digital, climate cooperation; "non-Western, not anti-Western"; IBSA coordination.

PRELIMS FODDER

- Evolution: BRIC coined 2001 (Jim O'Neill); first foreign ministers' meeting 2006; first summit 2009 Yekaterinburg; South Africa joined 2011; 2024 Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, UAE joined and the partner category was created at Kazan; 2025 Indonesia joined. India's 2026 roster counts Saudi Arabia among 11 members, though Saudi Arabia calls itself an "invited country" without formal ratification.
- Partner countries (10): Belarus, Bolivia, Cuba, Kazakhstan, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda, Uzbekistan, Vietnam.
- NDB: agreed at Fortaleza (2014), HQ Shanghai, President Dilma Rousseff. CRA: USD 100 billion liquidity arrangement. Ezulwini Consensus (2005): two permanent seats with veto and five non-permanent seats for Africa. CCIT: proposed by India in 1996, still not adopted. Members hold nearly half of world population and about 40% of global GDP (PPP).

MAINS FODDER

- Keywords: Multi-alignment; Reformed multilateralism; Global South; Payment interoperability; Implementation gap

PYQ: 2026 Mains: BRICS as an alternative to other groupings. 2025 Prelims: Kazan summit under Russia; Indonesia became a full member; the 16th summit theme was not "Strengthening Multiculturalism".

3.3 26th SCO Summit: Bishkek Declaration

PRELIMS + MAINS

What: 26th SCO Heads of State Council met in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan; SCO's 25th anniversary; Bishkek Declaration adopted. Theme: "25 Years of the SCO: Together for Sustainable Peace, Development and Prosperity". Pakistan took the 2026-27 chair and hosts the 2027 summit.

Members (10)	→ Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan.
Security	→ terrorism condemned "in all its forms", double standards rejected, CCIT supported; independent, neutral, peaceful Afghanistan with inclusive government; strikes on Iran condemned; just settlement of Palestine question; anti-drug programmes to 2030.
Institutions	→ Protocol amending the Charter makes English an official language; regulations for the Universal Centre for Countering Security Challenges and Threats and the Executive Committee of the SCO Anti-Drug Centre.
Economy	→ Economic Development Strategy and Energy Cooperation Strategy to 2030; transport corridors, smart customs; SCO Development Bank progressing among interested members; road map to raise national-currency share in settlements; IMF/World Bank reform; opposed unilateral coercive measures.
Environment and tech	→ Memorandum on combating climate change; Initiative on Biodiversity Conservation with Joint Action Plan 2026-31; AI memorandum; emergency assistance statement. People-to-people: Civilisational Dialogue Forum in India (autumn 2026); Lahore SCO Tourism and Cultural Capital 2026-27.
India at Bishkek	→ SCO vision of Security, Connectivity, Opportunity; "dismantle the entire ecosystem of terrorist financing, recruitment, radicalisation and safe havens"; "terrorism can never be a strategic asset for anyone"; connectivity must respect sovereignty and territorial integrity (CPEC through PoJK); met Russia, Iran, Kyrgyzstan, Armenia; informal interaction with China's President.
Importance for India	→ multi-alignment and strategic autonomy; Connect Central Asia; counter-terror cooperation via RATS; Afghanistan stability; Chabahar and INSTC; shaping agenda (English, Civilisational Dialogue Forum, Start-up and Young Scientists forums).
Limits	→ India-Pakistan and India-China differences; declaration rejects double standards but names no attack; BRI disagreement; China's weight; Pakistan's chairship; consensus slows decisions, implementation gap.
Way forward	→ use RATS effectively; operationalise the new security bodies; turn connectivity into trade (Chabahar-INSTC); use English and Indian initiatives to widen role; keep working-level engagement with Pakistan chair; track delivery through the Secretariat.

PRELIMS FODDER

- Shanghai Five (1996) became SCO (2001); Charter signed 2002. India and Pakistan joined 2017, Iran 2023, Belarus 2024.
- Secretariat in Beijing; RATS permanent body in Tashkent against the "three evils": terrorism, separatism, extremism.
- Bishkek attendees: Mongolia (observer); dialogue partners Armenia, Azerbaijan, Egypt, Laos, Türkiye.
- Shanghai Spirit: mutual trust, mutual benefit, equality, consultation, respect for cultural diversity, common development. Green Technology Corridor programme 2026-30.

MAINS FODDER

- Quote (PM, Bishkek 2026): "We must transform our shared geography into shared opportunities."
- Keywords: multi-alignment, Eurasian engagement, regional integration, consensus-building, implementation gap.

PYQ: 2023 Mains: "Virus of Conflict is affecting the functioning of the SCO" and India's role. 2021 Mains: aims and objectives of SCO and its importance for India.

3.4 India and Central Asia

PRELIMS + MAINS

What: The PM visited Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan and attended the 26th SCO Summit.

Uzbekistan → ties upgraded from Strategic Partnership to Comprehensive Strategic Partnership; trade target US$5 billion by 2030; cooperation to conserve Buddhist sites Fayaz Tepa and Kara Tepa in Termez; US$1 million grant for afforestation in the Aral Sea region. Kyrgyzstan: Strategic Partnership reaffirmed.

Trade → merchandise trade US$1.72 billion (2023). Uzbekistan about 45% of India's exports to the region; Kazakhstan supplied 64% of imports. India exports pharma, electrical equipment, machinery; imports mineral fuels, fertilisers, inorganic chemicals, ores. New BITs signed with Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan.

Significance → energy (Central Asia holds over 35 billion barrels proven oil; TAPI to tap Galkynysh field); uranium (Kazakhstan world's largest producer); crossroads location; pharma market (Uzbekistan imports about 30% of drugs from India); RATS in Tashkent; all five support India's permanent UNSC seat.

Challenges → no direct land access (Pakistan, Afghanistan); China dominance and BRI; Chabahar/ Iran route disruption and US sanctions; TAPI incomplete; second India-Central Asia Summit not held; withdrawal from Tajikistan's Ayni airbase.

Way forward → accelerate INSTC and Ashgabat Agreement; critical minerals via KABIL (as in Australia, Argentina, Chile); share DPI (UPI, Aadhaar); convene the overdue second summit.

PRELIMS FODDER

- All five states are landlocked; Uzbekistan is doubly landlocked (only other: Liechtenstein).
- Ashgabat Agreement: multimodal transport and transit pact linking Central Asia with the Persian Gulf. INSTC: initiated by India, Russia, Iran in 2000.
- Mechanisms: India-Central Asia Business Council, Digital Partnership Forum, Rare Earth Forum. Exercises: KAZIND (Kazakhstan), DUSTLIK (Uzbekistan).

MAINS FODDER

- Keywords: Connect Central Asia policy, Chabahar, INSTC, TAPI, counter-terror cooperation.

PYQ: 2024 Mains: India's evolving relations with Central Asian Republics. 2017 Prelims: importance of Chabahar port.

3.5 India-Mercosur: expanding the PTA

PRELIMS + MAINS

What: In September 2026 India and Mercosur announced negotiations to expand their Preferential Trade Agreement.

Mercosur → Southern Common Market, Treaty of Asunción 1991; Common External Tariff; members Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, Uruguay, Bolivia; Venezuela suspended.

Evolution → 2004 PTA signed, 2009 implemented, 2026 expansion talks. Trade grew from about $10.6 billion (2020) to $20.84 billion (2025). Indian exports: refined petroleum, chemicals, pharma, engineering, vehicles, textiles; imports: crude oil, soybean and sunflower oils, gold, sugar. Brazil is the main partner.

Opportunities → export diversification (medicines, chemicals, machinery); critical minerals (KABIL 2024 deal for five lithium blocks in Argentina); biofuels (Global Biofuels Alliance founders India and Brazil); food security; pharma investment; South-South cooperation, DPI sharing.

Challenges → narrow product list; non-tariff barriers (drug approvals, plant health); logistics costs; competing domestic sensitivities; supply shocks (Argentina 2023 drought).

Way forward → expand market access with safeguards; ease trade (customs, approvals; 2026 India-Brazil medicines agreement); shipping links, EXIM Bank São Paulo office; production partnerships; use the PTA Joint Administrative Committee.

POINTS → Existing PTA covers limited goods: India gives preferences on 450 tariff lines, Mercosur on 452.

PRELIMS FODDER

- Mercosur Secretariat: Montevideo; Protocol of Ouro Preto (1994) set institutions. Associate members: Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, Guyana, Suriname.
- IBSA Dialogue Forum 2003 (Brasilia Declaration): India, Brazil, South Africa.
- SPS Agreement (food safety, animal and plant health) and TBT Agreement (technical regulations) are the WTO frameworks for non-tariff measures.

MAINS FODDER

- Keywords: open regionalism, South-South cooperation, trade complementarity, supply-chain resilience, strategic diversification.

3.6.1 UNGA "Correct the Map" resolution

PRELIMS

What: UNGA adopted the "Correct the Map" resolution promoting maps that show continents' relative sizes accurately. Led by Togo for African countries with the African Union.

Vote → 164 in favour, US against, six abstentions. Non-binding; encourages equal-area projections such as Equal Earth. India voted in favour.

Why → Mercator enlarges regions near poles; Africa (about 30.3 million sq km) looks similar to Greenland (2.16 million sq km). Colonial-era mapping conventions shape perceptions.

Mercator → conformal cylindrical, 1569, for navigation, preserves angles and shapes. Equal Earth: equal-area pseudocylindrical, introduced 2018, preserves relative areas.

PRELIMS FODDER

- Every flat map distorts area, shape, direction or distance.

MAINS FODDER

- Keywords: Map projection; Equal Earth; Mercator

3.6.2 US-Denmark-Greenland defence agreement

PRELIMS + MAINS

What: The US, Denmark and Greenland signed an agreement strengthening Greenland and Arctic defence; Greenland is an autonomous territory of Denmark.

Provisions → modernise and expand Pituffik Space Base; two new Defence Areas at Narsarsuaq (south) and Mestersvig (east); extensive US access and movement rights including territorial waters; non-NATO states barred from military installations or persistent presence.

Importance → location between North America and Europe; ice sheet second largest after Antarctica (full melt about 7 m sea-level rise); Northwest Passage and Transpolar Sea Route opening; 25 of the 34 minerals on the EU critical raw materials list.

POINTS → Affirms Danish sovereignty and Greenlanders' right to self-determination; amends the 1951 US-Denmark Defense Agreement (under NATO).

MAINS FODDER

- Keywords: Arctic; Pituffik; Critical raw materials

3.6.3 Indus Waters Treaty: Court of Arbitration ruling

PRELIMS + MAINS

What: The Court of Arbitration (secretariat: Permanent Court of Arbitration) held that the IWT remains fully in force despite India's abeyance decision, and imposed temporary limits on specified construction at the Ratle Hydroelectric Project. India rejected the award as illegally constituted and without jurisdiction over its sovereign decisions.

IWT 1960

→ India and Pakistan, World Bank facilitated and signatory. Eastern rivers Ravi, Beas, Sutlej to India; Western rivers Indus, Jhelum, Chenab mainly to Pakistan, India keeps irrigation and hydropower uses.

CoA view

→ treaty cannot be unilaterally suspended or ended; Court has jurisdiction; Ratle limits until Neutral Expert decides. India: abeyance continues; Court constituted contrary to the treaty; rulings have no legal effect.

POINTS

→ Permanent Indus Commission (one commissioner each). Dispute ladder: Commission, then Neutral Expert, then Court of Arbitration. Modification or termination only by a duly ratified treaty.

→ After the 2025 Pahalgam attack India held the treaty in abeyance.

MAINS FODDER

- Link with water diplomacy and sovereignty versus treaty obligation arguments.
- Keywords: Abeyance; Court of Arbitration; Ratle

PYQ: 2016 Mains: account of the Indus Water Treaty and its ecological, economic and political implications.

3.7 IR quick updates

PRELIMS

What: Short items from the September 2026 current affairs.

Sohar Port (Oman)

→ deep-sea port on the Gulf of Oman outside the Strait of Hormuz, with Sohar Freezone; Oman invited Indian firms to invest as Hormuz disruptions hit Gulf trade.

L.69 Group

→ 40+ developing countries seeking comprehensive UNSC reform; named after draft resolution A/61/L.69 (2007, 61st UNGA). EAM co-chaired the consultation with Saint Lucia.

FIPIC

→ India with 14 Pacific Island Countries since 2014; summits 2014 Suva, 2015 Jaipur, 2023 Port Moresby; 12-Point Action Plan (2023); second Foreign Ministers' meeting held in New York.

Visegrad Group (V4)

→ informal Central European platform of four countries; first India-V4 foreign ministers' meeting at the 81st UNGA; backed India's permanent UNSC seat.

POINTS

→ 1991 India-Pakistan Agreement on Advance Notice on Military Exercises, Manoeuvres and Troop Movements: a CBM; Article 10 says naval ships and submarines must not come within 3 nautical miles in international waters. India protested after an Indian Navy-Pakistani vessel collision in the Arabian Sea.

→ Enemy state clauses (UN Charter Art. 53 and 107): Japan at the 81st UNGA asked for their removal. Amendment needs two-thirds of UNGA and ratification by two-thirds of members including all five P5.

→ Partners for Multilateralism (P4M): launched at its first summit; India co-sponsored with EU, Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada, Kenya; defends UN Charter, reform of institutions.

→ First International Space Summit, Paris: 90 countries and about 1,100 space companies; declarations on debris, orbital safety; EU IRIS² reaffirmed; ISRO-ESA cooperation extended to 2032.

3.8 High-level visits: Belgium and Luxembourg

PRELIMS

What: Belgian PM's first India visit: aim to double bilateral trade in five years, India-Belgium Investment Fast-Track Mechanism, CBI-Belgian Federal Police MoU on organised crime and cybercrime. Luxembourg's Deputy PM also visited.

Belgium (Brussels)

→ hosts European Commission, European Council, Council of the EU and NATO HQ; euthanasia legal since 2002, extended to minors of any age in 2014; early adopter of compulsory voting.

Luxembourg

→ landlocked, EU member; hosts the Court of Justice of the EU and the European Investment Bank; Schengen signed at Schengen village; Benelux with Belgium and the Netherlands.

3.9 Conflict areas in news

PRELIMS

What: West Asia and East Asia flashpoints in September 2026.

East Sea (Sea of Japan)

→ North Korea fired a projectile; semi-enclosed western Pacific sea; warm Tsushima Current meets cold Liman and North Korea currents giving fishing grounds; names: Japan "Sea of Japan", South Korea "East Sea", North Korea "East Sea of Korea".

POINTS

→ Perim Island (in the Bab el-Mandeb strait) and Greater and Lesser Hanish Islands (Red Sea): captured by the Houthis; drone attacks forced a temporary shutdown of Saudi Arabia's East-West Pipeline to Yanbu.

→ Ahmad al-Jaber (Kuwait) and Al Minhad (UAE) air bases: targeted by Iran; used by national and allied forces including the US.